

SUMMARY

Background

The contradiction between the goals of preserving built heritage and its practical implementation can be seen in many ways. Legislation and strategic programs appear to lead towards preservation and sustainability, but in practice the action is often the opposite. At a strategic level, built heritage is framed as a resource for sustainability and well-being. This is often not recognized at the municipal level, however, where most of the decisions concerning built heritage are made. More and more buildings are being demolished for economic reasons. Citizens are encouraged to act on behalf of built heritage, but their opportunities to influence the decision-making process are often weak. Sustainable development has been the framework for preserving built heritage since the 1990s. In recent years, the climate discussion has once again made the theme relevant. However, the preservation of existing buildings continues to be marginalized, and the discussion is often focused on energy efficiency.

This study examines the contradictions in the preservation of built heritage as they exist in Finland at the beginning of 2020s. The research questions address what societal structures and cultural practices cause contradictions, how they appear and what maintains them. The current situation is analyzed through the lens of the stages of Finnish building culture and the development of legislation that currently frames built heritage issues. The research is situated within the field of museology and multidisciplinary research into built heritage and cultural environment studies.

Method

Grounded theory and two sets of research materials are used in this study. The first data collection targeted media articles from 2018 to 2020. I collected 756 articles from Finnish newspapers nationwide. I researched what kind of public image of built heritage is conveyed through the media. As a second set of material, I conducted 20 interviews with experts working in the field of built environment. They included built heritage specialists, property developers, decision-makers, planners, citizen activists, and researchers. I analyzed how experts see the situation of built heritage preservation from their point of view.

In grounded theory, data collection is connected to analysis from the beginning. The basic concept of the data analysis is the constant comparative method and coding process. The researcher compares properties and categories and asks questions from the data, such as “what exactly is going on here”. Important and meaningful categories are discovered based on the data without the use of previous concepts or theories. The researcher must be as sensitive to the data as possible, but not in a tabula rasa manner. The researcher’s prior knowledge is used to inform analysis, not to direct it.